



Linnæus University

Sweden

Action plan

CoARA Action Plan 2024-2028

*Implementing the Agreement for Reforming
Research Assessment at Linnæus University*



Compilation of actions

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Introduction

Linnæus University signed *the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA)* on April 6, 2023. This document is an action plan specifying how Linnæus University shall meet the agreement's core commitments within its stipulated timeframe. This action plan is hereby shared with the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) community in accordance with the stipulations of the agreement.

When the university decided to sign ARRA, the university had recently signed *the San Francisco Declaration of Research Assessment (DORA)* and had already begun work to live up to DORA. Additionally, the university had been awarded the *HR Excellence in Research Award* by the European Commission on February 26, 2021. Linnæus University's recently adopted framework for research quality assurance was also written to be compatible with DORA and the possibility of signing ARRA was already being evaluated. Thus, much work to adapt to CoARA was already being undertaken or prepared.

Interpretation of the goals of the agreement

By joining CoARA, Linnæus University has committed to reforming research assessment practices to recognise the diverse outputs, practices and activities that maximise the quality and impact of research¹.

CoARA expands upon existing initiatives and largely gives direction and structure to initiatives and work already ongoing at the university. Additionally, the shared commitments to research assessment reform within the coalition, will facilitate a transformation of the entire European research system. Thus, Linnæus University has committed to:

1. **Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research** in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.
2. **Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation** for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators.
3. **Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics**, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index.
4. **Avoid the use of rankings** of research organisations in research assessment.

The core commitments are supported by six practical commitments:

¹ A full explanation of the commitments is available at <https://coara.eu/agreement/the-commitments/>



5. **Commit resources to reforming research assessment** as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to.
6. **Review and develop** research assessment criteria, tools and processes.
7. **Raise awareness of research assessment reform** and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use.
8. **Exchange practices and experiences** to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition.
9. **Communicate progress** made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments.
10. **Evaluate practices, criteria and tools** based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research.

Specific areas of action

This section briefly describes certain specific areas of action where Linnæus University have undertaken or are planning to undertake specific activities connected to CoARA.

Implementation of the Linnæus University's framework for research quality assurance – commitment 1, 2 and 6

The Linnæus University's framework for research quality came applicable on October 1, 2022 (henceforth "the framework"). It has its core values in academic freedom, good research practice, and collegial forms of working such as peer review. The framework is in line with the core and practical commitments of CoARA agreement as well as the *San Fransisco Declaration of Research Assessment* (DORA).

The framework is decentralised, and research assessment is mainly conducted at the faculties² and the Board of Teacher Education. This ensures that research assessments are based on practices and indicators suitable for the respective scientific disciplines and research types. Decentralisation adds diversity, inclusiveness and collaboration as well as broadens the recognition of the different research roles.

The challenge in a decentralised model lies in combining and coordinating these disciplinary practices to a university joint system, the framework. A university joint system is necessary due to national regulations³ and criteria⁴ set by the Swedish Higher Education Authority. Therefore, the implementation of the framework

² The five faculties are the School of Business and Education, the Faculty of Health and Life Sciences, the Faculty of Art and Humanities, the Faculty of Social Sciences, and the Faculty of Technology.

³ The Swedish Higher Education Act (1992:1434)

⁴ <https://www.uka.se/download/18.43165d7218b84ee3e676a7dd/1699362224821/Guidelines%20for%20reviewing%20HEIs%20quality%20assurance%20processes.pdf>



begins with a general assessment of how the faculties are putting the framework into action. This assessment is scheduled to run through 2024 and 2025.

The main goal is to follow up faculties' plans and/or work on implementing the framework and to ensure that this work meets the requirements set for the university and is carried out in accordance with the university's commitments. Other objectives are to find common ways of working through the exchange of experience and collegial support as well as to identify needs for common processes and principles.

The outcomes will be used to further develop the framework as well as a starting point of a systematic follow-ups to ensure quality assurance of research. This work will also be part of the university's role in the reforming research assessment according to the CoARA.

Open Science at Linnæus University – commitment 1, 5, 6, 7, 9 and 10

The goal of Linnæus University's Open Science project⁵ is for the entire university to be guided by the principle of "as open as possible, as closed as necessary".

Achieving this requires effective support where it is easy to do the right thing. The ultimate justification for this is to realise academic freedom in a digitized world.

Open Science is the Enlightenment ideal adapted for the digital age. Linnæus University believes that transformation to Open Science and reformed research assessment both need and benefit from a close connection.

The Open Science project is divided into five subprojects:

1. Open access to research data
2. Open access to scholarly publications
3. Open educational resources
4. Incentive system in the form of funding and recognition of qualifications
5. Collaboration and public engagement

As one of five sub-projects, Incentive structure in the form of funding and recognition of qualifications, takes charge of the university's work to support the transition to Open Science through a development of the incentive structures. The Open Science project – including the subproject devoted to incentives – will present a report in April 2025. This report will include suggestions for reformulating policy documents, improve practices, strengthening peer review to support Open Science by reforming incentive structures and assessment procedures.

Hiring, promoting, and rewarding researchers – commitment 1, 2, 5, 6 and 7

Within a project of supporting the transition to Open Science, Linnæus University has established a working group to create a structure of incentives rewarding open science. This working group was established in September 2023 and has been given a mandate to evaluate existing rules and practices and suggest improvements to create incentives supporting the transition to Open Science and to ensure that the

⁵ <https://lnu.se/en/meet-linnaeus-university/open-science/>



rules and practices of the university conforms with CoARA. The project is currently engaging with faculty, raising awareness of CoARA, and gathering views and suggestions. During fall 2024 the working group will present a map of rules and practices in need of improvement in order to conform with CoARA. Suggestions for changes will be made during spring 2025 and a final report will be presented to the vice chancellor in May 2025. Linnaeus University will also engage in creating and supporting a national chapter within CoARA.

Reviewing the university's usage of rankings – commitment 4

The university does not currently use any rankings for the purpose of hiring, promoting, or evaluating staff. No financial decisions are made based on rankings. The university does currently deliver information to the *Times Higher Education ranking*. This will be subject to review during 2025 or 2026.

Ensuring responsible use of metrics – commitment 2, 3, 5, 6 and 10

Ensuring responsible use of metrics is part of the general assessment described in section *Implementation of the Linnaeus University's framework for research quality assurance*. Additionally, the university has been harmonising usage of metrics, creating recommendations on suitable metrics for every level of the university, and ensuring unsuitable uses are being phased out. These goals should be accomplished by 2025. Finally, the above-mentioned Open Science project will deliver recommendations for further work on Open Science metrics by April 2025.

Before signing CoARA, the allocation of research funding to the faculties was partially based on publications. The publications were graded in three different classes according to prestige, following the Norwegian Register for Scientific Journals, Series, and Publishers. This manner of re-allocation was found to be non-compatible with CoARA and was abandoned in 2023.

Usage of metrics, such as publications, citations, success in attracting external funding etc., are used, but generally accompanied by a qualitative analysis and discussion between concerned parties. Journal Impact Factors and h-index is not required usage at any level of the university. The usage of these sort of indexes is discouraged, but not outright forbidden. There is no systematic usage of these indexes by the university at this point, though there are individual examples of use for example in applications for open positions.

HR Excellence in Research (HRS4R) – commitment 5, 6, 8, 9 and 10

Linnaeus University was awarded *the HR Excellence in Research* in 2021 and the interim assessment was approved in 2023.

The current timeline at Linnaeus University for HR Excellence in Research is focused on implementation of the updated action plan and will be finalized by an external evaluation by the EU Commission in 2026.

Currently the university is working with strategies for research communication. For example, the university is reviewing options for a research information management system compatible with the *Barcelona declaration*.



EUniWell – commitment 2, 5, 8, 9

Linnæus University is a part of the European University for Well-Being (EUniWell, one of the designated thematic university alliances within the European University Initiative). Several of our partner universities have also signed CoARA, and collaboration within EUniWell will implement CoARA as far as possible during the ongoing work period of 2023-2027.

Examining the compatibility of accreditations and CoARA – commitment 1, 5, 7, 10

In 2023, the School of Business and Economics at Linnæus University was awarded the Association to Advance Collegiate Schools of Business accreditation. Linnæus University finds this accreditation to be broadly compatible with CoARA, especially the AACSB focus on the societal impact of research. Eventual conflicts between the AACSB-accreditation and CoARA will be examined during 2024 and 2025.